Introduction: AI Training for Beginners

AI Training for Beginners

Self-study training: use AI/LLMs safely in everyday life

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https://github.com/mgunthner/AI-Training

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Introduction: AI Training for Beginners

1. Welcome and goal

You already use AI in everyday life or want to get started with it. In this training you will learn how to use AI **safely, sensibly and with cost awareness**. After the training you will be able to: - explain what an AI chatbot can and cannot do - write requests (prompts) that deliver usable results - recognize wrong answers and manipulation attempts - decide which data belongs in a chat and which does not - understand what agents, interfaces (APIs) and the like are

2. Who is this training for?

For everyone without prior knowledge. All you need is a device with internet access and access to any AI service – a free plan is enough. The training is vendor-neutral: everything works with any common service (e.g. ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, Copilot).

3. How the training works

You learn by self-study, at your own pace. Per topic (about 25–30 min.): 1. **Read the cheatsheet** (about 10 min.) 2. **Do the exercise** (5–10 min.) 3. **Extra exercises** (optional) 4. **Questions?** Ask them as an issue in the GitHub repo 5. **Test** after each block

Choose your learning path:

Path	Duration	For whom
Quick start	about 3 hrs.	everyone, mandatory part
Standard	about 1 day	regular users
Advanced	about 2 days	tech enthusiasts

You can find the exact topics per path in the roadmap (`AI-Training_Roadmap`). You can always go deeper later.

4. Material overview (in this repo)

Folder / file	Content
00_introduction_handout	this handout
01_cheatsheets/	24 cheatsheets, each about one page
02_extra_exercises/	Extra tasks for topics 01–23
03_tests/	Entrance test, quick test, block tests A–F, final test, solutions separate
04_trainer/	Question template and FAQ
05_progress/learning_progress	Checklist to tick off
06_capstone/	Capstone project (after the final test): project instructions, example portfolio, checklist
AI-Training_Roadmap	Learning paths and topic plan in detail

Work through the topics in numerical order. They build on each other.

5. Five safety rules up front

1. **Enter no passwords, keys or sensitive data** (also no other people's data).
2. **Check results** before you use or share them. "Sounds convincing" does not mean "is true".
3. **Do not blindly trust third-party content** (websites, documents, emails can contain hidden instructions).
4. **Confirm actions with consequences yourself** (sending, deleting, paying, publishing).
5. **Know your privacy settings**: Check what your service stores and whether your inputs are used for training.

6. Getting ready to start

- ☐ Create an account with an AI service of your choice
- ☐ Open and check the privacy settings (storage, use for training, history)
- ☐ Create your own **practice chat** (e.g. "AI training") to collect your exercises
- ☐ Create a note file for your **prompt library**

Tip: For exercises, use only **invented or anonymized data**, e.g. "Person A" or "Company X".

7. Tests and progress

The tests are not a report card but a mirror: they show you what has stuck and what you should review. - **Entrance test** (10 questions): before you start, not graded. It shows your starting point. (03_tests/entrance_test) - **Block tests:** after each block – Test A (03_tests/test_A_foundation), Test B (03_tests/test_B_good_results), Test C (03_tests/test_C_risks), Test D (03_tests/test_D_-technology_costs), Test E (03_tests/test_E_agentic_systems), Test F (03_-tests/test_F_final) - **Quick test: quick start:** after the quick start path (03_tests/quick_test_quickstart) - **Final test:** at the end, mixes knowledge and practice (03_tests/final_test) - **Pass mark:** 75 %. You grade it yourself, using

the solutions file. You assess practice tasks with the self-assessment rubric (`03_tests/self_assessment`) – criterion by criterion, stricter rather than lenient when in doubt. Only look at the solution when you are done. - **Not passed?** The solution names the topics you should review. After that you can retake the test. - **After that?** With the capstone (`06_capstone/project_instructions`) you turn what you have learned into your own project – optional in the Standard path, recommended in the Advanced path.

Tick off your progress in the checklist (read / practiced / test passed).

8. Extra exercises

For every topic there are 3–5 extra tasks in three levels: ★ entry, ★★ everyday, ★★★ challenge. Use them when you want to consolidate a topic or the regular exercise was too easy. Solution approaches are at the end of the file.

9. Asking questions (GitHub issues)

You can ask questions at any time, especially when you get stuck on an exercise. The way to do that is through **issues in this GitHub repo**: - Open the repo and create a new issue under **Issues**. - Copy the template from `04_trainer/question_template` into the issue and fill it in: - Name the **topic** (number of the cheatsheet). - Write what you **wanted to achieve** and what you **tried**. - Say **where you are stuck**. - **Anonymize** prompts and results before you write them into the issue. No sensitive or personal data – issues are publicly visible.

Solved questions are collected anonymously in the FAQ.

> Note: If you do not have a GitHub account, you will need a one-time free account to be able to create an issue.

10. Learning tips

- Better small units than one long marathon.
- Apply every topic immediately to a real everyday task (email, vacation, shopping, learning).
- Take notes and collect successful prompts in your **prompt library**, from day 1.
- Experiment, compare results and question them.

11. Mini glossary

Term	Meaning
AI	Computer programs that solve tasks for which you would otherwise need human thinking
LLM	Language model: a program that understands and generates text by predicting the most likely next word
Prompt	Your input or instruction to the AI

Term	Meaning
Token	Small chunk of text in which the AI processes and bills text
Context	Everything the AI currently has “in front of it” in a chat (history, files, instructions)
Hallucination	An invented answer that sounds convincing
Model	The “engine” behind the chat; there are larger and smaller ones
Plan	Your plan with the provider (e.g. free or subscription) with its own limits
API	Interface through which programs talk to the AI directly
Agent	AI that independently plans multiple steps and executes them with tools

12. Important notes

- Providers change features, limits and prices often. Always check current details with the provider.
- The content is general orientation, **not legal advice**. If in doubt, ask a specialist or your data protection officer.
- AI makes mistakes. You remain responsible for what you do with the results.

13. Checklist: Ready to start?

☐ I have access to an AI service.
☐ I know the five safety rules.
☐ I have checked my privacy settings.
☐ I have chosen my learning path.
☐ I have taken the entrance test.

Let’s get going with cheatsheet 01: What is AI? (`01_cheatsheets/01_what_is_ai`)

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